

FREE RESOURCE

# The Pre-Shoot Client Questionnaire

10 questions to ask every client before you book the session

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Most photographers — especially beginners — skip the pre-shoot conversation. A client messages, you say yes, you show up, and then you discover they wanted 4 hours of coverage, 200 edited photos, and a same-day delivery. That's not a client problem. That's a scope problem you created by not asking questions.

# The 10 questions

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## 1. What's the occasion?

A family session, a product shoot, an event, a headshot — the occasion drives everything else: location, gear, time, and price.

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ANSWER:

## 2. When and where?

Get the date, time, and exact location. "Sometime next month" is not a booking. If it's outdoors, have a rain plan.

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ANSWER:

## 3. How long do you need me?

One hour, half a day, full day? This is the single biggest driver of your price. Get it in hours, not vibes.

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ANSWER:

## 4. What do you want the photos for?

Personal use, social media, a business website, print? Usage changes licensing and price. A business using your photos commercially is worth more than a family posting to Instagram.

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ANSWER:

## 5. How many photos do you expect?

"A few good ones" means something different to every client. Set the number up front — 15 edited photos is a concrete deliverable; "a few" is a negotiation.

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ANSWER:

## 6. Who's in the shoot?

Number of people, ages, any pets. A newborn session is a different shoot than a 20-person family reunion.

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ANSWER:

## 7. Do you have a location in mind, or do you need suggestions?

If they have a spot, ask for photos of it. If not, you suggest — and you control the lighting conditions.

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ANSWER:

## 8. What's your style reference?

Ask for 2–3 photos they like. This aligns expectations before you shoot, not after. It also tells you if they want bright-and-airy or moody-and-dramatic.

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ANSWER:

## 9. What's your budget?

Yes, ask directly. If they won't answer, that's information. A client who won't state a budget is a client who'll be shocked by your price.

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ANSWER:

## 10. How do you want the photos delivered?

Online gallery, USB, prints? Delivery method affects your workflow and your cost.

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ANSWER:

**Why this protects you:** Every one of these questions is a scope-setting tool. When you ask them in writing, you create a record. If a client later says “I thought you'd include 100 photos,” you point to the answer to question 5. The questions also filter clients — someone who answers all 10 clearly is a client you want; someone who dodges the budget question is a tire-kicker. Better to find that out in five minutes than on shoot day.

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